An Introduction to Relative Langlands Duality

Fatih
Middle East Technical University

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Abstract

These are notes for an introductory lecture on the relative Langlands duality proposed by Ben-Zvi, Sakellaridis and Venkatesh [1]. After recalling the structure theory of algebraic groups needed to define the Langlands dual group, we explain how periods of automorphic forms are indexed by spherical varieties and, more intrinsically, by hyperspherical Hamiltonian spaces; we state the local, global and numerical forms of the duality; and we describe the four-dimensional topological field theory picture that organizes them. The last section explains how Hamiltonian spaces appear as Lagrangians in shifted symplectic stacks, and lists some questions. No originality is claimed except where explicitly stated.

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1 Introduction

Automorphic forms carry two kinds of numerical invariants. Integrating an automorphic form against a distinguished cycle gives a *period*; evaluating the L-function of its Langlands parameter gives an *L-value*. Since Hecke's work in 1937, many identities of the form

$$\text{period of } \varphi \;\doteq\; \text{special value of an } L\text{-function of } \varphi$$

have been found, where $\doteq$ means equality up to explicit and well-understood factors. In the language of the Langlands program these identities say that a diagram

$$\begin{array}{ccc} \{\text{automorphic forms on } G\} & \overset{\text{Langlands}}{\longleftrightarrow} & \{\text{Galois representations into } G^\vee\} \\ & \searrow^{\text{period}} \quad \swarrow_{L\text{-function}} & \\ & \mathbb{C} & \end{array} \tag{1.1}$$

commutes. Relative Langlands duality, as formulated by Ben-Zvi, Sakellaridis and Venkatesh [1], proposes a systematic explanation:

1. periods for G are indexed by Hamiltonian G-spaces M;
2. L-functions for $G^\vee$ are indexed by Hamiltonian $G^\vee$-spaces $M^\vee$;
3. there is a duality $(G, M) \leftrightarrow (G^\vee, M^\vee)$ on a well-behaved class of such spaces, the *hyperspherical* ones, under which (1.1) commutes;
4. analogous statements hold in every "tier" of the Langlands program: local and global, arithmetic and geometric.

A first example, from the introduction of [1]: for $G = \mathrm{GL}_n \times \mathrm{GL}_n$, the Godement–Jacquet and Rankin–Selberg integrals are dual to each other. The Godement–Jacquet period of φ is the L-function indexed by the Rankin–Selberg space, and vice versa. Classically these are two separate theorems [9, 12]; from the present point of view they are one statement read in two directions.

Outline. Section 2 recalls the structure theory of linear algebraic groups up to reductive groups. Section 3 defines root data and the Langlands dual group. Section 4 discusses periods and spherical varieties, and Section 5 hyperspherical varieties and the duality. Section 6 states the conjectures, Section 7 explains the field-theoretic picture, and Section 8 discusses shifted symplectic geometry and open questions. The report [2] of the 2025 Oberwolfach Arbeitsgemeinschaft is a useful companion survey.

Conventions. In Sections 2–3, k is an algebraically closed field and an *algebraic group* means a smooth affine group scheme of finite type over k; algebraic subgroups are closed. From Section 4 on, G is a split connected reductive group over a field F, and the dual group $G^\vee$ is defined over a coefficient field of characteristic zero ($\mathbb{C}$ or $\overline{\mathbb{Q}}_\ell$). We work in the unramified setting throughout. When F is a local field we write $\mathcal{O}$ for its ring of integers, typically $F = \mathbb{C}((t))$, $\mathcal{O} = \mathbb{C}[[t]]$ in the geometric setting. Page numbers for [1] refer to the version on Sakellaridis's webpage; section numbers agree with the arXiv version.

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2 Background on algebraic groups

The goal of this section is the definition of a reductive group. The definition says that a certain normal subgroup, the unipotent radical, is trivial; to make sense of it we need solvable, nilpotent and unipotent groups. Standard references are [14, Ch. 6, 14, 16, 17, 19], [20] and [11].

2.1 Examples

Example 2.1. The following algebraic groups will be used throughout.

- $\mathbb{G}_a = (k, +)$, the additive group, with coordinate ring $k[x]$.
- $\mathbb{G}_m = (k^\times, \cdot)$, the multiplicative group, with coordinate ring $k[x, x^{-1}]$.
- A *torus* is an algebraic group isomorphic to $\mathbb{G}_m^r$ for some r.
- GL_n, SL_n, $\mathrm{PGL}_n = \mathrm{GL}_n/\mathbb{G}_m$, Sp_{2n}, SO_n.
- $B_n \subset \mathrm{GL}_n$, the upper triangular invertible matrices.
- $U_n \subset B_n$, the upper triangular matrices with 1's on the diagonal.
- $T_n \subset B_n$, the diagonal matrices; $T_n \cong \mathbb{G}_m^n$.

2.2 Subnormal series

Definition 2.2. A *subnormal series* of an algebraic group G is a chain of algebraic subgroups

$$G = G_0 \supset G_1 \supset \cdots \supset G_s = \{e\}$$

such that each G_{i+1} is normal in G_i. The groups G_i/G_{i+1} are its *quotients*. A subnormal series is *normal* if each G_i is normal in G, and *central* if moreover G_i/G_{i+1} lies in the centre of G/G_{i+1}.

Quotients of algebraic groups by normal algebraic subgroups exist and are again algebraic groups [14, Ch. 5], so this definition behaves as in abstract group theory.

Example 2.3. In B_n, let $U_n^{(j)}$ be the subgroup of U_n of matrices u with $u_{ab} = 0$ for $0 < b - a < j$, i.e. vanishing on the first $j-1$ superdiagonals. Then

$$B_n \supset U_n = U_n^{(1)} \supset U_n^{(2)} \supset \cdots \supset U_n^{(n)} = \{e\}$$

is a normal series. Its first quotient is $B_n/U_n \cong T_n \cong \mathbb{G}_m^n$ (take the diagonal), and each later quotient $U_n^{(j)}/U_n^{(j+1)}$ is isomorphic to $\mathbb{G}_a^{n-j}$ (take the j-th superdiagonal).

2.3 Solvable and nilpotent groups

For an algebraic group G, the *derived group* $\mathcal{D}G = [G, G]$ is the smallest algebraic subgroup containing all commutators; it is normal, and connected if G is. Set $\mathcal{D}^0 G = G$ and $\mathcal{D}^{i+1} G = \mathcal{D}(\mathcal{D}^i G)$ (derived series), and $C^0 G = G$, $C^{i+1} G = [G, C^i G]$ (lower central series).

Definition 2.4. An algebraic group G is

1. *solvable* if it has a subnormal series with commutative quotients; equivalently, $\mathcal{D}^s G = \{e\}$ for some s;
2. *nilpotent* if it has a central series; equivalently, $C^s G = \{e\}$ for some s.

Nilpotent groups are solvable. Subgroups, quotients and (for solvable groups) extensions of solvable groups are solvable; subgroups and quotients of nilpotent groups are nilpotent.

Example 2.5.

1. Tori and $\mathbb{G}_a$ are commutative, hence nilpotent.
2. B_n is solvable by Example 2.3.
3. U_n is nilpotent: the series $U_n^{(j)}$ is central.
4. B_2 is solvable but not nilpotent. Its centre is the scalar matrices Z, and $B_2/Z \cong \mathbb{G}_a \rtimes \mathbb{G}_m$, with $\mathbb{G}_m$ acting on $\mathbb{G}_a$ by scaling, has trivial centre; so the upper central series of B_2 stops at $Z \neq B_2$.
5. GL_n and SL_n ($n \geq 2$) are not solvable: $\mathcal{D}\mathrm{SL}_n = \mathrm{SL}_n$.

Theorem 2.6 (Lie–Kolchin)**.** *Let $G \subset \mathrm{GL}(V)$ be a connected solvable algebraic group. Then G fixes a full flag in V. Equivalently, in a suitable basis $G \subset B_n$.*

So B_n is, up to conjugation, the universal connected solvable subgroup of GL_n. This motivates:

Definition 2.7. A *Borel subgroup* of G is a maximal connected solvable algebraic subgroup.

Theorem 2.8 (Borel)**.** *Let G be connected. Any two Borel subgroups of G are conjugate, G/B is a projective variety, and any two maximal tori of G are conjugate. Every maximal torus lies in some Borel subgroup.*

For $G = \mathrm{GL}_n$, the Borel subgroups are the conjugates of B_n, and GL_n/B_n is the variety of full flags in k^n.

2.4 Unipotent groups

Definition 2.9. An element $g \in \mathrm{GL}(V)$ is *unipotent* if $g - 1$ is nilpotent. An algebraic group U is *unipotent* if every nonzero representation V of U has a nonzero fixed vector.

Iterating the defining property, every representation of a unipotent group has a full flag of invariant subspaces on which U acts trivially on the quotients. Hence:

Proposition 2.10. *An algebraic group is unipotent if and only if it is isomorphic to an algebraic subgroup of U_n for some n, if and only if all its elements are unipotent. Unipotent groups are nilpotent.*

Example 2.11. $\mathbb{G}_a$ and U_n are unipotent. A torus is never unipotent unless trivial: $\mathbb{G}_m$ acts on k by the identity character with no fixed vector. Unipotent groups and tori are the two opposite extremes; by the Jordan decomposition, every element of GL_n factors uniquely as $g = g_s g_u = g_u g_s$ with g_s semisimple and g_u unipotent.

Theorem 2.12 (Structure of connected solvable groups)**.** *Let G be connected and solvable, and let G_u be the set of unipotent elements. Then G_u is a connected normal algebraic subgroup, and for any maximal torus $T \subset G$,*

$$G = T \ltimes G_u.$$

For $G = B_n$ this is the decomposition $B_n = T_n \ltimes U_n$.

2.5 The radical and the unipotent radical

Let G be connected. If $N_1, N_2 \subset G$ are connected normal solvable subgroups, so is $N_1 N_2$, being an extension of $N_2/(N_1 \cap N_2)$ by N_1. Hence there is a largest one, and similarly for unipotent subgroups.

Definition 2.13. Let G be a connected algebraic group.

1. The *radical* $R(G)$ is the largest connected normal solvable algebraic subgroup of G.
2. The *unipotent radical* $R_u(G)$ is the largest connected normal unipotent algebraic subgroup of G.

Since unipotent groups are solvable, $R_u(G) \subset R(G)$; in fact $R_u(G) = R(G)_u$ by Theorem 2.12.

Example 2.14.

1. $R(\mathrm{GL}_n) = Z(\mathrm{GL}_n) = \mathbb{G}_m$ (scalar matrices) and $R_u(\mathrm{GL}_n) = \{e\}$.
2. $R(\mathrm{SL}_n) = R_u(\mathrm{SL}_n) = \{e\}$.
3. $R(B_n) = B_n$ and $R_u(B_n) = U_n$.
4. Let $P \subset \mathrm{GL}_n$ be the block upper triangular matrices with diagonal blocks of sizes $n_1, \dots, n_r$ (a *parabolic* subgroup). Then $R_u(P)$ is the subgroup of block upper triangular matrices whose diagonal blocks are identity matrices, and

$$P = L \ltimes R_u(P), \qquad L = \mathrm{GL}_{n_1} \times \cdots \times \mathrm{GL}_{n_r} \text{ (the Levi factor).}$$

2.6 Reductive and semisimple groups

Definition 2.15. A connected algebraic group G is

1. *reductive* if $R_u(G) = \{e\}$;
2. *semisimple* if $R(G) = \{e\}$.

Over a field that is not algebraically closed, one requires these conditions after base change to an algebraic closure.

Semisimple groups are reductive. By Example 2.14, GL_n is reductive but not semisimple, SL_n is semisimple, and B_n and proper parabolic subgroups are not reductive. The groups PGL_n, Sp_{2n}, SO_n ($n \geq 3$) are semisimple, and tori are reductive.

Theorem 2.16. *Let G be a connected algebraic group.*

1. *If G is reductive, then $R(G) = Z(G)^\circ$ is a torus, $\mathcal{D}G$ is semisimple, and the multiplication map $R(G) \times \mathcal{D}G \to G$ is a surjection with finite kernel. For instance $\mathrm{GL}_n = \mathbb{G}_m \cdot \mathrm{SL}_n$ with kernel μ_n.*
2. *If $\operatorname{char} k = 0$, G is reductive if and only if every finite-dimensional representation of G is completely reducible.*

3. *(Levi decomposition,* $\operatorname{char} k = 0$*.) There is a reductive subgroup* $L \subset G$ *with* $G = L \ltimes R_u(G)$.

Part (2) explains the name: $\mathbb{G}_a$ acting on k^2 by $x \mapsto \begin{pmatrix} 1 & x \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ preserves the line ke_1 but has no invariant complement. Part (3) says that every connected group is built from a reductive group and a unipotent group, which is why reductive groups are the central objects of the theory.

Exercise 2.17. Show directly that $R_u(\mathrm{GL}_n) = \{e\}$: a connected normal unipotent subgroup of GL_n fixes a nonzero subspace of k^n, which is then GL_n-stable.

3 Root data and the Langlands dual group

3.1 Root data

Let G be connected reductive and $T \subset G$ a maximal torus. Write

$$X^* = X^*(T) = \operatorname{Hom}(T, \mathbb{G}_m), \qquad X_* = X_*(T) = \operatorname{Hom}(\mathbb{G}_m, T)$$

for the character and cocharacter lattices. Composition gives a perfect pairing

$$\langle\ ,\ \rangle : X^* \times X_* \to \mathbb{Z}, \qquad (\chi \circ \lambda)(s) = s^{\langle \chi, \lambda \rangle},$$

since $\operatorname{Hom}(\mathbb{G}_m, \mathbb{G}_m) = \mathbb{Z}$.

The torus T acts on $\mathfrak{g} = \operatorname{Lie}(G)$ through the adjoint representation, and $\mathfrak{g} = \operatorname{Lie}(T) \oplus \bigoplus_{\alpha \in \Phi} \mathfrak{g}_\alpha$, where $\Phi \subset X^* \setminus \{0\}$ is the set of *roots*. Each $\mathfrak{g}_\alpha$ is one-dimensional. For each root α there is a homomorphism $\varphi_\alpha : \mathrm{SL}_2 \to G$, unique up to conjugation by T, whose differential maps the upper and lower triangular nilpotent matrices to $\mathfrak{g}_\alpha$ and $\mathfrak{g}_{-\alpha}$. The *coroot* is

$$\alpha^\vee \in X_*, \qquad \alpha^\vee(s) = \varphi_\alpha \begin{pmatrix} s & 0 \\ 0 & s^{-1} \end{pmatrix},$$

and satisfies $\langle \alpha, \alpha^\vee \rangle = 2$. The reflections $s_\alpha(x) = x - \langle x, \alpha^\vee \rangle \alpha$ preserve Φ and generate the *Weyl group* $W = N_G(T)/T$.

Definition 3.1. A *root datum* is a quadruple $(X, \Phi, X^\vee, \Phi^\vee)$ where $X, X^\vee$ are free abelian groups of finite rank in perfect duality, $\Phi \subset X$ and $\Phi^\vee \subset X^\vee$ are finite subsets with a bijection $\alpha \mapsto \alpha^\vee$, such that $\langle \alpha, \alpha^\vee \rangle = 2$ and the reflections s_α, $s_{\alpha^\vee}$ preserve Φ, $\Phi^\vee$ respectively. It is *reduced* if $2\alpha \notin \Phi$ for $\alpha \in \Phi$.

The *root datum of* G is $\Psi(G) = (X^*, \Phi, X_*, \Phi^\vee)$; it is independent of T up to isomorphism by Theorem 2.8.

Theorem 3.2 (Chevalley; Demazure–Grothendieck)**.** *The assignment* $G \mapsto \Psi(G)$ *induces a bijection between isomorphism classes of connected reductive groups over* k *(equivalently, split reductive groups over any field) and isomorphism classes of reduced root data.*

See [14, Ch. 21, 23 and App. C].

3.2 The dual group

Definition 3.3. The *dual* of a root datum $\Psi = (X, \Phi, X^\vee, \Phi^\vee)$ is $\Psi^\vee = (X^\vee, \Phi^\vee, X, \Phi)$. The *Langlands dual group* of G is the connected reductive group $G^\vee$ over $\mathbb{C}$ with

$$\Psi(G^\vee) = \Psi(G)^\vee.$$

It exists and is unique up to isomorphism by Theorem 3.2. Some immediate consequences:

- The maximal torus of $G^\vee$ is $T^\vee = X^*(T) \otimes \mathbb{C}^\times$, so $X^*(T^\vee) = X_*(T)$.
- G and $G^\vee$ have isomorphic Weyl groups.
- $G^\vee$ depends only on the combinatorics of G; it is a complex group even when G is defined over $\mathbb{F}_q$ or $\mathbb{Q}_p$.
- The centre $Z(G^\vee)$ is Cartier dual to the algebraic fundamental group $\pi_1(G) = X_*/\mathbb{Z}\Phi^\vee$. In particular G is simply connected iff $G^\vee$ is adjoint.

Example 3.4 (GL_n is self-dual)**.** Let $T = \{\mathrm{diag}(t_1, \dots, t_n)\}$. Then $X^* = \mathbb{Z}^n$ with basis $e_i(t) = t_i$, and $X_* = \mathbb{Z}^n$ with basis

$$e_i^\vee(s) = \mathrm{diag}(1, \dots, \underset{i}{s}, \dots, 1), \qquad \langle e_i, e_j^\vee \rangle = \delta_{ij}.$$

The torus acts on the matrix unit E_{ij} by $t_i t_j^{-1}$, so $\Phi = \{e_i - e_j : i \neq j\}$. The copy of SL_2 in rows and columns i, j gives

$$\alpha_{ij}^\vee(s) = \mathrm{diag}(\dots, \underset{i}{s}, \dots, \underset{j}{s^{-1}}, \dots), \qquad \alpha_{ij}^\vee = e_i^\vee - e_j^\vee,$$

and $\langle e_i - e_j, e_i^\vee - e_j^\vee \rangle = 2$. The dual datum $(\mathbb{Z}^n, \{e_i^\vee - e_j^\vee\}, \mathbb{Z}^n, \{e_i - e_j\})$ is the same datum with letters renamed, so

$$\mathrm{GL}_n^\vee \cong \mathrm{GL}_n(\mathbb{C}).$$

Example 3.5 (SL_n and PGL_n)**.** Both groups have roots $e_i - e_j$; only the lattices change. With $\mathbf{1} = (1, \dots, 1)$:

	X^*	X_*
SL_n	$\mathbb{Z}^n/\mathbb{Z}\mathbf{1}$	$\{a \in \mathbb{Z}^n : \sum a_i = 0\}$
PGL_n	$\{a \in \mathbb{Z}^n : \sum a_i = 0\}$	$\mathbb{Z}^n/\mathbb{Z}\mathbf{1}$

The two rows are exchanged by duality, so $\mathrm{SL}_n^\vee \cong \mathrm{PGL}_n(\mathbb{C})$ and $\mathrm{PGL}_n^\vee \cong \mathrm{SL}_n(\mathbb{C})$. Consistently with the remark on centres, $Z(\mathrm{SL}_n) = \mu_n$ is dual to $\pi_1(\mathrm{PGL}_n) = \mathbb{Z}/n$, and $\pi_1(\mathrm{SL}_n) = 0$ is dual to $Z(\mathrm{PGL}_n) = 1$. For $n = 2$: SL_2 has $X^* = \mathbb{Z}$ with root 2 and $X_* = \mathbb{Z}$ with coroot 1; swapping gives root 1 and coroot 2, the root datum of PGL_2.

Example 3.6 (Types B and C)**.** For SO_5 (type B_2), $\Phi = \{\pm e_1, \pm e_2\} \cup \{\pm e_1 \pm e_2\}$, the first set short and the second long. The coroots are $\Phi^\vee = \{\pm 2e_1^\vee, \pm 2e_2^\vee\} \cup \{\pm e_1^\vee \pm e_2^\vee\}$, now with the first set long: this is type C_2. In general $\mathrm{SO}_{2n+1}^\vee \cong \mathrm{Sp}_{2n}(\mathbb{C})$ and $\mathrm{Sp}_{2n}^\vee \cong \mathrm{SO}_{2n+1}(\mathbb{C})$.

G	$G^\vee$	G	$G^\vee$
GL_n	GL_n	SO_{2n}	SO_{2n}
SL_n	PGL_n	Spin_{2n+1}	PSp_{2n}
SO_{2n+1}	Sp_{2n}	G_2, F_4, E_8	G_2, F_4, E_8
$\mathbb{G}_m$	$\mathbb{G}_m$		

3.3 Why the dual group appears

Theorem 3.7 (Satake)**.** *Let G be split reductive over $\mathbb{Q}_p$. Unramified irreducible representations of $G(\mathbb{Q}_p)$ are in bijection with semisimple conjugacy classes in $G^\vee(\mathbb{C})$.*

If s_π is the class attached to π (its *Satake parameter*) and V is a representation of $G^\vee$, the local L-factor is

$$L(s,\pi,V) = \det\left(1 - s_\pi\, p^{-s} \mid V\right)^{-1}.$$

For $G = \mathrm{GL}_n$, $s_\pi = \mathrm{diag}(\alpha_1,\dots,\alpha_n)$ and the standard representation gives $L(s,\pi) = \prod_i (1-\alpha_i p^{-s})^{-1}$. For $n=1$ the Satake bijection is local class field theory for unramified characters. See [4, 10].

The geometric Satake equivalence of Mirković–Vilonen gives an intrinsic construction: $G^\vee$ is the Tannakian group of the category of $G(\mathcal{O})$-equivariant perverse sheaves on the affine Grassmannian $\mathrm{Gr}_G = G(F)/G(\mathcal{O})$, $F = \mathbb{C}((t))$ [21]. Relative Langlands duality may be viewed as asking what replaces $G^\vee$ when Gr_G is replaced by $X(F)/G(\mathcal{O})$ for a G-variety X. The answer will be a Hamiltonian $G^\vee$-space.

4 Periods and spherical varieties

4.1 Periods

Let F be a global field with adeles $\mathbb{A}$, and write $[G] = G(F)\backslash G(\mathbb{A})$. For an algebraic subgroup $H \subset G$ and an automorphic form φ on $[G]$, the *H-period* of φ is

$$P_H(\varphi) = \int_{[H]} \varphi(h)\, dh,$$

when convergent. More generally, a G-variety X defines a theta series on $[G]$ from Schwartz functions on $X(\mathbb{A})$, and the X-period is the pairing of φ with it; for $X = H\backslash G$ one recovers P_H.

Example 4.1 (Hecke)**.** Let $G = \mathrm{PGL}_2$, $A = \{\mathrm{diag}(a,1)\} \cong \mathbb{G}_m$ and φ in a cuspidal automorphic representation π. Then

$$\int_{F^\times\backslash\mathbb{A}^\times} \varphi\begin{pmatrix} a & \\ & 1 \end{pmatrix} |a|^{s-\frac12}\, d^\times a \;\doteq\; L(s,\pi).$$

At $s = \frac12$, the A-period of φ is the central value $L(\frac12,\pi)$, the L-function of the standard representation $\mathbb{C}^2$ of $G^\vee = \mathrm{SL}_2(\mathbb{C})$.

Thus the automorphic datum $(\mathrm{PGL}_2,\ A\backslash\mathrm{PGL}_2)$ corresponds to the spectral datum $(\mathrm{SL}_2,\ \mathbb{C}^2)$. This is the first example of a dual pair.

4.2 Spherical varieties

Definition 4.2. A normal G-variety X is *spherical* if a Borel subgroup of G has an open orbit on X.

Example 4.3.

1. Toric varieties, for G a torus.
2. Flag varieties G/P, by the Bruhat decomposition.
3. The *group case*: $X = G$ under $G \times G$ acting by $(g_1,g_2)\cdot x = g_1 x g_2^{-1}$. The big Bruhat cell is an open orbit of $B \times B^-$.
4. Symmetric varieties G/G^θ for an involution θ, e.g. $\mathrm{GL}_{2n}/\mathrm{Sp}_{2n}$ and $\mathrm{GL}_{2n}/(\mathrm{GL}_n \times \mathrm{GL}_n)$.
5. $A\backslash\mathrm{PGL}_2$ from Example 4.1, and $(\mathrm{GL}_{n+1}\times\mathrm{GL}_n)/\Delta\mathrm{GL}_n$, which underlies Rankin–Selberg and Gan–Gross–Prasad periods.

The relevance of sphericity is the *multiplicity one* phenomenon: for a local field F and many spherical X,

$$\dim \mathrm{Hom}_{G(F)}\left(\pi, C^\infty(X(F))\right) \leq 1$$

for every irreducible π. When local multiplicities are at most one, a global period is forced to factor as a product of local functionals, and an Euler product, hence an L-function, appears. Multiplicity one does not hold for every spherical variety, and the definition of hyperspherical variety in Section 5 is in part an abstraction of this property [1, Rem. 1.2.2].

Example 4.4. In the group case, $\mathrm{Hom}_{G\times G}(\pi \boxtimes \sigma, C^\infty(G))$ is nonzero iff $\sigma \cong \pi^\vee$, and is then one-dimensional by Schur's lemma. The corresponding global period is the Petersson inner product, related to $L(1, \pi, \mathrm{Ad})$.

See [16, 5] for introductions to spherical varieties.

5 Hamiltonian spaces and hyperspherical varieties

A basic insight of [1] is that periods are *microlocal*: they should be attached not to X but to T^*X, viewed as a Hamiltonian G-space. Symmetries such as the Fourier transform underlying Tate's thesis are visible on $T^*\mathbb{A}^1$ but not on $\mathbb{A}^1$. Moreover, important periods, such as Whittaker periods and theta correspondences, come from Hamiltonian spaces that are not cotangent bundles at all. For background on the symplectic geometry below see [7, Ch. 1]; for a detailed treatment of hyperspherical varieties see [1, §3] and the notes [17].

5.1 Algebraic symplectic geometry

Let M be a smooth variety over $\mathbb{C}$ and $\Omega^p_M = \wedge^p \Omega^1_M$ the sheaf of Kähler p-forms. A *symplectic form* is $\omega \in H^0(M, \Omega^2_M)$ with $d\omega = 0$ such that $T_M \to \Omega^1_M$, $v \mapsto \iota_v \omega$, is an isomorphism.

Example 5.1. On $T^*\mathbb{A}^n = \mathrm{Spec}\,\mathbb{C}[q_1, \ldots, q_n, p_1, \ldots, p_n]$, $\omega = \sum dp_i \wedge dq_i$. More generally, for smooth X the cotangent bundle T^*X carries the canonical 1-form θ, locally $\sum p_i\, dq_i$, and $\omega = d\theta$ is symplectic.

Each $f \in \mathcal{O}(M)$ has a *Hamiltonian vector field* H_f defined by $\iota_{H_f}\omega = df$, and $\{f, g\} = \omega(H_f, H_g)$ is a Poisson bracket on $\mathcal{O}(M)$.

Let $\mathfrak{g}^* = \mathrm{Hom}(\mathfrak{g}, \mathbb{C})$ be the dual of the Lie algebra, with the coadjoint action $(g \cdot \lambda)(\xi) = \lambda(\mathrm{Ad}(g^{-1})\xi)$.

Definition 5.2. A *Hamiltonian G-space* is a symplectic variety M with a G-action preserving ω and a G-equivariant *moment map* $\mu : M \to \mathfrak{g}^*$ such that, for every $\xi \in \mathfrak{g}$, the vector field generated by ξ is H_{μ_ξ}, where $\mu_\xi = \langle \mu, \xi \rangle$.

Example 5.3. If G acts on a smooth variety X, then T^*X is a Hamiltonian G-space with

$$\mu(x, p)(\xi) = p(\xi \cdot x),$$

where $\xi \cdot x \in T_x X$ is the infinitesimal action. For $G \times G$ acting on $T^*G \cong G \times \mathfrak{g}^*$ (trivialized by left translation), $\mu(g, \lambda) = (\mathrm{Ad}^*_g \lambda, -\lambda)$.

Definition 5.4. The *Hamiltonian reduction* of M by a subgroup H is $M/\!\!/\!\!/H = \mu_H^{-1}(0)/H$, where μ_H is the composite $M \to \mathfrak{g}^* \to \mathfrak{h}^*$.

For instance $T^*G/\!\!/\!\!/H \cong T^*(G/H)$, with H acting by right translation.

Exercise 5.5. Verify that the map in Example 5.3 is a moment map.

5.2 The grading

Definition 5.6. A *graded Hamiltonian G-space* is a Hamiltonian G-space M with an action of $\mathbb{G}_{\mathrm{gr}} \cong \mathbb{G}_m$ commuting with G such that $a^*\omega = a^2\omega$ for $a \in \mathbb{G}_{\mathrm{gr}}$. The moment map is then $\mathbb{G}_{\mathrm{gr}}$-equivariant for the action $a \cdot \lambda = a^2\lambda$ on $\mathfrak{g}^*$.

On T^*X one may let $\mathbb{G}_{\mathrm{gr}}$ act on cotangent fibres by $p \mapsto a^2 p$, so that $\omega = \sum dp_i \wedge dq_i$ has weight 2. On the spectral side the grading becomes the cohomological grading in the geometric setting and the Frobenius weight in the arithmetic setting; see [1, §1.4, §2.8] for the precise conventions.

5.3 Hyperspherical varieties

Definition 5.7 ([1, §3.5])**.** A graded Hamiltonian G-space M is *hyperspherical* if, roughly,

1. M is smooth and affine;
2. M is *coisotropic*: the invariant functions $\mathcal{O}(M)^G$ Poisson-commute, equivalently generic G-orbits are coisotropic;
3. the image of μ meets the nilpotent cone of $\mathfrak{g}^*$;
4. certain further technical conditions hold, concerning connectedness of generic stabilizers and the $\mathbb{G}_{\mathrm{gr}}$-action.

We refer to [1, §3.5] for the precise statement. Condition (2) is the Hamiltonian counterpart of sphericity: by work of Knop, for a smooth affine spherical variety X the cotangent bundle T^*X is coisotropic.

5.4 The structure theorem

Theorem 5.8 ([1, Thm. 3.6.1])**.** *Every hyperspherical G-space is obtained by* Whittaker induction *from a triple*

$$\big(H \subset G \text{ reductive}, \quad \iota : \mathrm{SL}_2 \to G \text{ commuting with } H, \quad S \text{ a symplectic representation of } H\big).$$

When ι is trivial, Whittaker induction is ordinary Hamiltonian induction:

$$M = \big(T^*G \times S\big) /\!\!/\!\!/ H \cong G \times^H \big(\mathfrak{h}^\perp \times S\big), \qquad \mathfrak{h}^\perp \subset \mathfrak{g}^*.$$

With $S = 0$ this recovers $T^*(G/H)$. A nontrivial ι twists the construction by a Whittaker datum along the nilpotent element $\iota\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$.

Remark 5.9. The triple in Theorem 5.8 matches the classification of half-BPS boundary conditions of $\mathcal{N} = 4$ super Yang–Mills theory by Gaiotto and Witten [8]: a Nahm pole (ι), a subgroup (H), and a theory of hypermultiplets (S). See [1, Rem. 1.2.1] and Section 7.

5.5 The duality

BZSV expect [1, §5.2] that for "anomaly-free" hyperspherical (G, M) there is a dual hyperspherical $(G^\vee, M^\vee)$, with $(M^\vee)^\vee \cong M$. For polarized $M = T^*X$ they construct a candidate $M^\vee$ explicitly [1, §4] from three ingredients: the dual group $G_X^\vee \subset G^\vee$ of the spherical variety X (Gaitsgory–Nadler, Sakellaridis–Venkatesh, Knop–Schalke), a homomorphism $\mathrm{SL}_2 \to G^\vee$ commuting with $G_X^\vee$, and a symplectic representation S_X of $G_X^\vee$.

Name	(G, M)	$(G^\vee, M^\vee)$
Group case	$(G \times G,\ T^*G)$	$(G^\vee \times G^\vee,\ T^*G^\vee)$
Whittaker–trivial	$(G,\ \mathrm{pt})$	$(G^\vee,\ T^*_\psi(G^\vee/U^\vee))$
Hecke	$(\mathrm{PGL}_2,\ T^*(A\backslash \mathrm{PGL}_2))$	$(\mathrm{SL}_2,\ T^*\mathbb{C}^2)$
Iwasawa–Tate	$(\mathbb{G}_m,\ T^*\mathbb{A}^1)$	$(\mathbb{G}_m,\ T^*\mathbb{A}^1)$
GJ–RS*	$(\mathrm{GL}_n \times \mathrm{GL}_n,\ T^*\mathrm{Mat}_{n\times n})$	$(\mathrm{GL}_n \times \mathrm{GL}_n,\ T^*(G \times^{\Delta \mathrm{GL}_n} \mathbb{A}^n))$
Gan–Gross–Prasad	$(\mathrm{SO}_{2n} \times \mathrm{SO}_{2n+1},\ T^*(\mathrm{SO}_{2n+1}/\mathrm{SO}_{2n}))$	$(\mathrm{SO}_{2n} \times \mathrm{Sp}_{2n},\ \mathrm{std} \otimes \mathrm{std})$

*Godement–Jacquet and Rankin–Selberg; $G = \mathrm{GL}_n \times \mathrm{GL}_n$.

A selection from [1, Table 1.5.1]. The Hecke row recovers Example 4.1: $M^\vee = T^*\mathbb{C}^2$ is the cotangent bundle of the standard representation of SL_2. The Whittaker row explains the special role of the Whittaker model: the Whittaker period is dual to the trivial L-function. In the Gan–Gross–Prasad row, $M^\vee$ is a symplectic representation that is not a cotangent bundle; such cases correspond to periods whose square, rather than the period itself, is an L-value.

6 The conjectures

Each conjecture asserts that an object built from (G, M) on the automorphic side matches an object built from $(G^\vee, M^\vee)$ on the spectral side.

6.1 Shearing

For a $\mathbb{G}_m$-equivariant complex $N = \bigoplus_i N_i$, with N_i the weight-i part, the *shear* is $N^\natural = \bigoplus_i N_i[i]$. Applied to $\mathcal{O}(M^\vee)$ with its $\mathbb{G}_{\mathrm{gr}}$-grading, shearing converts the grading into a cohomological shift. For example, $\mathcal{O}(\mathfrak{g}^*)$, generated in weight 2, becomes $\mathrm{Sym}(\mathfrak{g}[-2])$, and $\big(\mathcal{O}(\mathfrak{g}^*)^G\big)^\natural \cong H^*(BG)$. See [1, §6].

6.2 The local conjecture

Let X be an affine spherical G-variety, $M = T^*X$, $F = \mathbb{C}((t))$ and $\mathcal{O} = \mathbb{C}[[t]]$.

Conjecture 6.1 ([1, §7.5])**.** *There is an equivalence of categories, compatible with the Hecke actions through derived geometric Satake,*

$$\mathrm{Shv}\big(X(F)/G(\mathcal{O})\big) \simeq \mathrm{QC}^\natural\big(M^\vee/G^\vee\big).$$

Two consistency checks, each valid up to renormalization and support conditions:

1. For the group case $X = G$ under $G \times G$, the left side is $\mathrm{Shv}_{G(\mathcal{O})}(\mathrm{Gr}_G)$ and $M^\vee/(G^\vee \times G^\vee) \cong (\mathfrak{g}^\vee)^*/G^\vee$. Conjecture 6.1 becomes the derived geometric Satake equivalence of Bezrukavnikov–Finkelberg.
2. For $X = \mathrm{pt}$ the left side is $\mathrm{Shv}(BG(\mathcal{O}))$, controlled by $H^*(BG)$. The dual is the Whittaker space, and $M^\vee/G^\vee$ is identified with the Kostant slice $\cong (\mathfrak{g}^\vee)^*/\!\!/G^\vee$, whose sheared ring of functions is $H^*(BG)$.

6.3 The global conjecture

Let Σ be a smooth projective curve over $\mathbb{C}$. On the automorphic side, let

$$\mathrm{Bun}_G^X = \{(P, s) : P \text{ a } G\text{-bundle on } \Sigma,\ s \text{ a section of } P \times^G X\},$$

with projection $\pi : \mathrm{Bun}_G^X \to \mathrm{Bun}_G$, and define the *period sheaf* $\mathcal{P}_X = \pi_! \underline{k} \in \mathrm{Shv}(\mathrm{Bun}_G)$. On the spectral side, let

$$\mathrm{Loc}_{G^\vee}^{X^\vee} = \{(E, s) : E \text{ a } G^\vee\text{-local system, } s \text{ a flat section of } E \times^{G^\vee} X^\vee\},$$

with projection $p : \mathrm{Loc}_{G^\vee}^{X^\vee} \to \mathrm{Loc}_{G^\vee}$, and define the *L-sheaf* $\mathcal{L}_{X^\vee} = p_* \omega \in \mathrm{QC}(\mathrm{Loc}_{G^\vee})$.

Conjecture 6.2 ([1, §12.1])**.** *Under the geometric Langlands equivalence*

$$\mathrm{Shv}(\mathrm{Bun}_G) \simeq \mathrm{IndCoh}_{\mathcal{N}}(\mathrm{Loc}_{G^\vee}),$$

the normalized period sheaf $\mathcal{P}_X$ corresponds to the normalized L-sheaf $\mathcal{L}_{X^\vee}$.

The name is explained by the stalks: at a local system E, the stalk of $\mathcal{L}_{X^\vee}$ is computed by the space of flat sections of $E \times^{G^\vee} X^\vee$; for $X^\vee = V$ a vector space this involves $H^*(\Sigma, E_V)$, whose Frobenius trace in the arithmetic setting is an L-value. Feng and Wang have studied the Hecke case.

6.4 The numerical conjecture

Conjecture 6.3 ([1, §14.2], schematic)**.** *Let F be a global function field and π an everywhere unramified tempered cuspidal automorphic representation of G with Langlands parameter ϕ_π. For $\varphi \in \pi$,*

$$\frac{|P_X(\varphi)|^2}{\langle \varphi, \varphi \rangle} \doteq L_{M^\vee}(\phi_\pi),$$

and when $M^\vee = T^*V$ is polarized, $P_X(\varphi) \doteq L(\frac{1}{2}, \pi, V)$.

Known instances include the periods of Hecke, Iwasawa–Tate, Rankin–Selberg, Whittaker, and Gan–Gross–Prasad (via the Ichino–Ikeda conjecture). See [1, §14.5–14.6].

7 The field-theoretic picture

7.1 Langlands duality as a four-dimensional field theory

A fully extended four-dimensional topological field theory assigns a number to a closed 4-manifold, a vector space to a closed 3-manifold, a category to a closed surface, and a 2-category to a closed 1-manifold. Kapustin and Witten [13] showed that a twisted form of $\mathcal{N} = 4$ super Yang–Mills theory gives TFTs $\mathcal{A}_G$ (A-model) and $\mathcal{B}_{G^\vee}$ (B-model), and that electric-magnetic S-duality predicts

$$\mathcal{A}_G \simeq \mathcal{B}_{G^\vee}.$$

Evaluated on a curve Σ, this is the geometric Langlands equivalence between $\mathrm{Shv}(\mathrm{Bun}_G)$ and (a version of) $\mathrm{QC}(\mathrm{Loc}_{G^\vee})$. Hecke operators are line operators, and their duality is geometric Satake.

In arithmetic topology (Mazur, Kapranov, Reznikov, Morishita, Kim) number fields behave like 3-manifolds, local fields and function fields of curves like 2-manifolds, and $\mathbb{C}((t))$ like a 1-manifold. BZSV propose to view the whole Langlands program as an equivalence of two "four-dimensional arithmetic field theories", see [1, §1.3].

7.2 Boundary conditions

Gaiotto and Witten [8] explained that a Hamiltonian G-space M defines a boundary condition for four-dimensional G-gauge theory, namely a three-dimensional sigma model into M coupled to the bulk gauge field.

Conjecture 7.1 (Meta-conjecture, [1, Conj. 1.3.2])**.** *Under $\mathcal{A}_G \simeq \mathcal{B}_{G^\vee}$, the boundary condition Θ_M for $\mathcal{A}_G$ attached to M corresponds to the boundary condition $\mathcal{L}_{M^\vee}$ for $\mathcal{B}_{G^\vee}$ attached to $M^\vee$, for dual hyperspherical pairs $(G, M) \leftrightarrow (G^\vee, M^\vee)$.*

The conjectures of Section 6 are evaluations of this single statement. Place the theory on $N \times [0,1]$ with $N \times \{0\}$ labelled by M; then N acquires a distinguished element of whatever the theory assigns to N:

N	automorphic output	matching statement
global field ("3d")	period functional on automorphic forms	numerical conjecture
curve over $\mathbb{C}$ ("2d")	period sheaf in $\mathrm{Shv}(\mathrm{Bun}_G)$	global conjecture
$\mathbb{C}((t))$ ("1d")	module category $\mathrm{Shv}(X(F)/G(\mathcal{O}))$	local conjecture
interval with two boundaries	a number	relative trace formula

The field theory picture is not merely organizational: it predicts compatibilities between the conjectures, such as local-global compatibility through Θ-series [1, §15], and suggests new objects, such as the L-sheaf and the Plancherel algebra, which is related to the Coulomb branches of Braverman–Finkelberg–Nakajima [1, §8].

8 Shifted symplectic geometry and open questions

8.1 Hamiltonian spaces as Lagrangians

Pantev, Toën, Vaquié and Vezzosi [15] defined n-shifted symplectic structures on derived Artin stacks, and Lagrangian structures on maps into them. The derived intersection of two Lagrangians in an n-shifted symplectic stack is $(n-1)$-shifted symplectic. For reductive G with a nondegenerate invariant form on $\mathfrak{g}$, the classifying stack BG is 2-shifted symplectic, and

$$[\mathfrak{g}^*/G] \cong T^*[1]BG$$

is 1-shifted symplectic.

Theorem 8.1 (Calaque [6], Safronov [18])**.** *A Lagrangian structure on $[M/G] \to [\mathfrak{g}^*/G]$ is equivalent to the structure of a Hamiltonian G-space on M.*

Consequently Hamiltonian reduction is a Lagrangian intersection,

$$M/\!\!/\!\!/G = [\mu^{-1}(0)/G] = [M/G] \times_{[\mathfrak{g}^*/G]} BG,$$

and is therefore 0-shifted symplectic as a derived stack, even when 0 is not a regular value of μ; see [19].

8.2 Where derived geometry enters

- *Boundary conditions as Lagrangians.* Heuristically, the classical B-model for $G^\vee$ is an AKSZ-type theory with 3-shifted symplectic target $T^*[3]BG^\vee \cong (\mathfrak{g}^\vee)^*[2]/G^\vee$, and boundary conditions are Lagrangians in it. A Hamiltonian $G^\vee$-space gives a Lagrangian $M^\vee/G^\vee \to (\mathfrak{g}^\vee)^*/G^\vee$ in the 1-shifted target, and the $\mathbb{G}_{\mathrm{gr}}$-grading together with shearing moves it into the 3-shifted setting. This is one explanation of why the grading is part of the data.
- *Mapping stacks.* The stacks $\mathrm{Loc}_{G^\vee} = \mathrm{Map}(\Sigma_{dR}, BG^\vee)$ and $\mathrm{Loc}_{G^\vee}^{X^\vee} = \mathrm{Map}(\Sigma_{dR}, X^\vee/G^\vee)$ carry shifted symplectic and Lagrangian structures by the AKSZ construction, and the L-sheaf may be viewed as a quantization of such a Lagrangian.
- *Beyond varieties.* Many interesting dual pairs involve M that are singular, non-affine, or "not even a variety (e.g., a stack or derived scheme)" [1, p. 24]. For example $M = T^*(U\backslash G)$ under $T \times G$, related to Eisenstein series, is not affine.
- *Morphisms of periods.* BZSV suggest [1, p. 26] that morphisms between periods should be given by quantizations of Lagrangian correspondences between Hamiltonian G-spaces, as in unfolding arguments.

8.3 Questions

Question 8.2. Is there a general construction of $M^\vee$ from M? BZSV give one in the polarized case. Can the duality be read off from combinatorial invariants, extending the work of Knop and Losev [1, §1.6]?

Question 8.3. For which (G, M) is the duality defined? This is governed by an anomaly condition [1, §5.1].

Question 8.4. What is the correct derived framework for singular, non-affine and stacky M?

Question 8.5. The $\mathbb{G}_{\mathrm{gr}}$-action makes a hyperspherical M a conic symplectic variety. Conic symplectic varieties are symplectizations of contact varieties; for instance, the projectivization of the minimal nilpotent orbit is a contact variety [3]. Is there a shifted *contact* formulation of the Lagrangian $M/G \to \mathfrak{g}^*/G$ that captures the grading and shearing intrinsically? A first test is to compute, for the simplest dual pairs (Iwasawa–Tate, Hecke, Whittaker), the contact quotient of M minus its $\mathbb{G}_{\mathrm{gr}}$-fixed locus, and its shifted analogue, on both sides of the duality.

The last question is not taken from [1]; it is offered as a possible point of contact with derived contact geometry.

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